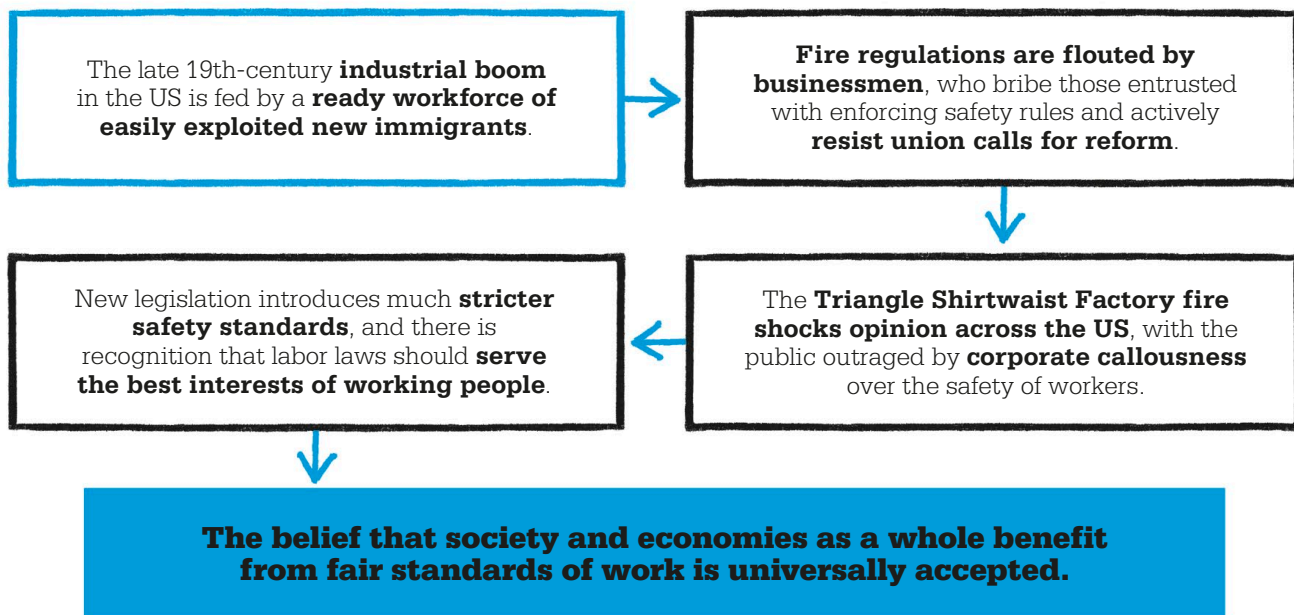


See also: The Trade Union Act 156–159 ■ The Workers' Accident Insurance System 164–167 ■ *Donoghue v. Stevenson* 194–195
 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The European Convention on Human Rights 230–233



and of corporate corner-cutting. Fire regulations were routinely ignored, and firefighters were poorly equipped, with little understanding of how to tackle a fire in the upper stories of an overcrowded building.

The tragedy highlighted a culture in which those enforcing safety regulations could be bribed by businessmen and shocked the whole country. As a result, it led to a series of much more stringent fire regulations, and union membership was similarly boosted.

Blanck and Harris

The men who owned the Triangle Shirtwaist Company—Max Blanck and Issac Harris, themselves Russian immigrants—were typical profiteers of their era and class. There had been four earlier fires in factories they owned, and the pair had benefited handsomely from insurance payouts each time. In 1909, they had conspired to break

a strike by the International Ladies' Garment Workers' Association by paying the police to beat the women and the politicians to look the other way. It has been suggested that the woefully inadequate fire precautions at the Triangle Factory were themselves a form of insurance; should the company falter, a fire could be advantageous. However, there is no suggestion the fire was started deliberately.

The fire

There were about 500 employees on the premises when the fire began, on the eighth floor, at about 4:40 P.M. It was almost certainly the result of a lit cigarette tossed into a steel bin containing several weeks' worth of scrap cotton and discarded tissue paper. The resulting flame ignited fabrics that were suspended from the ceiling. Somebody reached for the fire hose but found it had rotted, with its nozzle rusted shut. »



Firefighters douse the flames of the fire at the Asch Building's Triangle Shirtwaist Factory. The building was saved and still stands to this day, renamed the Brown Building.